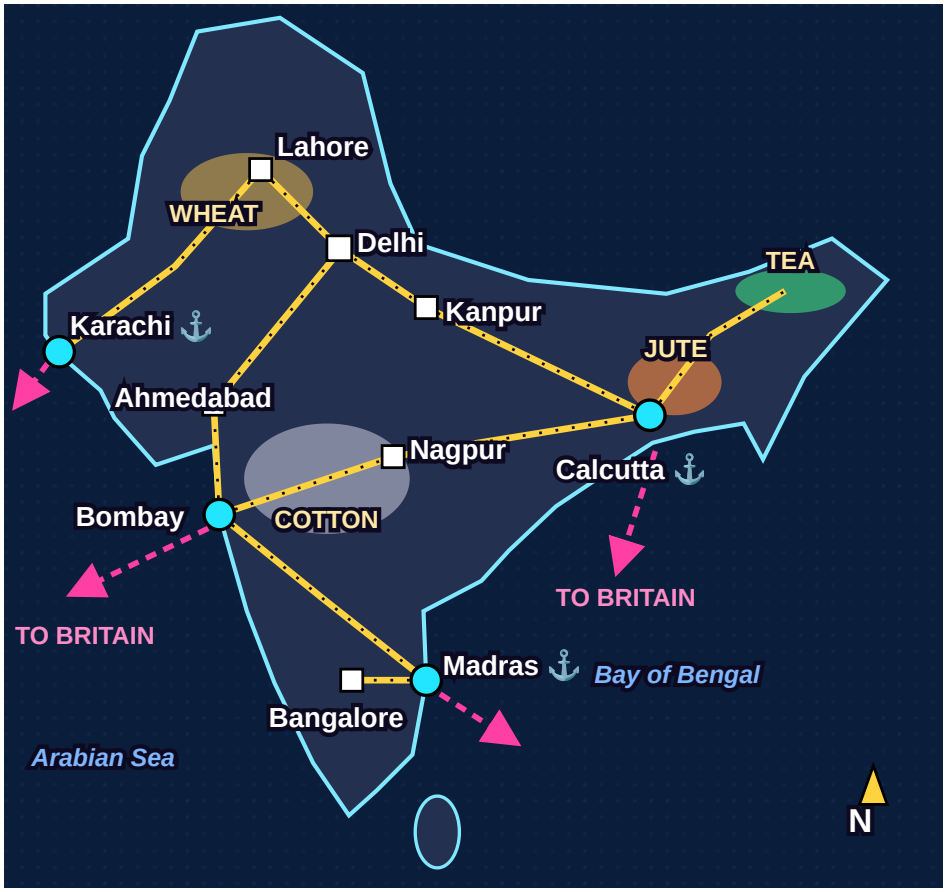
Rails of the Raj

AP Human Geography · Units 4 & 7 · One stimulus (like Question 2) · 7 points · Teacher key · GeoArcade FRQ Tutor

This map shows major railway lines in British India around 1900, the port cities they reached, and regions that specialized in export crops.

Railways, Ports, and Export Regions in British India, c. 1900



Railway · Port city · Inland city · Wheat · Cotton · Jute · Tea

Schematic map created for practice. Simplified, not to scale.

A. Identify the spatial pattern of the railway network shown on the map. IDENTIFY

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ANY ONE OF THESE:

- Lines link the interior to the export ports
- Lines converge on a few major cities (e.g., Bombay, Calcutta)

MODEL ANSWER

The railway lines run from the interior of India and converge on a few major port cities, such as Bombay and Calcutta.

Common mistake: “The railroads are all over India.” Too vague. It doesn't say WHAT the pattern is, and 'all over' could describe any map.

Why the model works: It names a specific pattern (interior → ports) and points to real places on the map.

B. Describe how the pattern of the railway network reflects Great Britain's economic goals in colonial India. DESCRIBE

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names the goal: extracting raw materials or cash crops for Britain
- Links the rail pattern to moving goods from the interior to ports for export

MODEL ANSWER

T1- The railway pattern reflects Britain's goal of extracting raw materials from India.
E2- The lines mostly run from crop-growing regions in the interior, like cotton in the Deccan and jute in Bengal, to the ports of Bombay and Calcutta.
A3- This let raw materials move quickly to ships bound for factories in Britain, which is exactly what a colonial economy was built to do.

Common mistake: "Britain wanted to make India better by building trains." No economic goal and no map evidence. It never mentions raw materials or ports.

Why the model works: It names the goal (raw materials), uses map evidence (crop regions linked to ports), and connects the two.

C. Explain how colonial rule contributed to the growth of port cities such as Bombay and Calcutta. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names a colonial function: export/trade hub, rail terminus, or administrative center
- Explains growth through jobs, investment, or migration

MODEL ANSWER

T1- Colonial rule made Bombay and Calcutta grow because they became the gateways between India and Britain.
E2- The rail lines ended there, so these cities handled the exports leaving India and the British goods arriving, which concentrated jobs in shipping, warehouses, banking, and government.
A3- Those jobs pulled in rural migrants, and more people brought more businesses, so they became some of South Asia's largest cities.

Common mistake: "Bombay and Calcutta grew because they were big cities." Circular reasoning: they grew because they were big? There's no cause and no process.

Why the model works: It walks the whole chain: colonial trade role → jobs → migration → growth.

D. Explain ONE way the colonial emphasis on export cash crops affected rural communities in South Asia. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names an effect: less food grown, famine, debt, poverty, or dependence on world prices
- Explains the cause-and-effect link to cash-crop farming

MODEL ANSWER

T1- The colonial push for export cash crops made rural families more vulnerable to hunger.
E2- Farmers were pressured to grow cotton and jute instead of food crops, so less land produced food and families depended on world prices they couldn't control.
A3- Because of this, when prices fell or a drought hit, people couldn't afford food, and drought years turned into deadly famines.

Common mistake: “Cash crops were bad for farmers.” It says 'bad' but not HOW. An Explain answer needs the cause-and-effect chain.

Why the model works: It names a specific effect (hunger and famine) and explains the chain that caused it.

E. Describe how the economic relationship shown on the map illustrates Wallerstein's world-system theory. DESCRIBE

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Places Britain as the core and India as the periphery
- Describes the flow: raw materials out to the core, manufactured goods or profits kept by the core

MODEL ANSWER

T1- In world-system theory, Britain was the core and India the periphery.
E2- The map shows India sending low-value raw materials like cotton and jute to ports for export to Britain.
A3- Britain turned those materials into manufactured goods and kept the higher profits and industrial jobs, which is how the core grows wealthy from the periphery.

Common mistake: “Wallerstein's theory says there are core and periphery countries.” It defines the theory but never applies it to Britain, India, or the map.

Why the model works: It labels each country AND uses the map's flow of raw materials to show the relationship.

F. Explain ONE way the colonial transportation network continues to affect patterns of economic development in South Asia today. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names a present-day pattern: old ports remain top economic hubs, or coast/interior development is uneven
- Explains why: existing infrastructure keeps attracting investment, industry, and migrants

MODEL ANSWER

T1- The colonial transportation network still concentrates development in the old port cities.
E2- Because colonial railways tied the economy to a few ports, cities like Mumbai and Kolkata got a head start in infrastructure, industry, and finance.
A3- That infrastructure keeps attracting new businesses and migrants (cumulative causation), so development is still uneven, with many interior rural regions lagging behind.

Common mistake: "India is still affected by colonialism today." True, but it names no specific effect and doesn't explain how the railways cause it.

Why the model works: It names a present-day pattern (old ports still lead) and explains why (infrastructure keeps attracting investment).

G. Explain ONE limitation of using this map to understand how colonialism affected people in South Asia. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- States a specific limit (no data on people, incomes, deaths, or experiences; a single time period; one scale)
- Explains why that prevents fully understanding colonialism's effects

MODEL ANSWER

T1- One limitation is that the map shows infrastructure, not people.
E2- It has no data on incomes, famine deaths, literacy, or how Indians experienced colonial rule.
A3- Because of that, it can't show who actually benefited or was harmed by the railways, so by itself it can't measure colonialism's human impact.

Common mistake: "The map is too small and hard to read." That's about the picture's quality, not its information. AP wants to know what content is missing.

Why the model works: It names specific missing data and explains which conclusion you can't reach without it.
